RAI-FM (DSE428/DSE628) — Assignment 3: Short Report

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1. Bias Audit of Foundation Models

Design

- **20 hypothesis-driven prompts** covering **10 bias dimensions × 2 prompts**: gender, caste (India), religion (India), regional representation (Global South), Indian English/Hinglish, socio-economic status, disability, age, cultural assumptions, institutional credibility.
- **Counterfactual templates:** only one attribute changes (e.g. “Amit Sharma” vs “Amit Jatav”; the same career question in English vs Hinglish); 6–8 paired names/cities/institutions per group, 2 samples each.
- **Scale:** 720 requests per model × condition; **8,640 responses** in total.
- **Answers in JSON**, so decisions (salary, risk, scores, yes/no) are extracted exactly; free text is labelled by an independent LLM classifier.
- **Storage:** every prompt, response, annotation, score and metadata (model, commit hash, seed, settings) saved in JSONL and CSV.

Models and analysis

- **Audited models** (local, bf16, temperature 0.7, top-p 0.9, max 400 tokens, fixed seeds): Qwen3-8B (Alibaba), Phi-4-mini-instruct 3.8B (Microsoft), Granite-3.3-8B-instruct (IBM), Falcon3-7B-Instruct (TII, UAE).
- **Judge / classifier:** OLMo-2-13B-Instruct (AI2), a developer not being audited.
- **Statistics:** the fill (name/institution) is the unit; stratified permutation tests, excess disparity over the noise floor, cluster-bootstrap CIs, Benjamini–Hochberg FDR over the 80 primary tests.
- **Novelty:** builds on StereoSet, CrowS-Pairs, BBQ, Indian-BhED, IndiBias, name-substitution audits (Haim et al. 2024; Tamkin et al. 2023) and matched-guise dialect probing (Hofmann et al., Nature 2024), but moves them into *Indian decision scenarios* (caste via surname in tenant screening, Hinglish matched guise, IIT vs school type, diet imputation) with a paired, fill-level analysis.

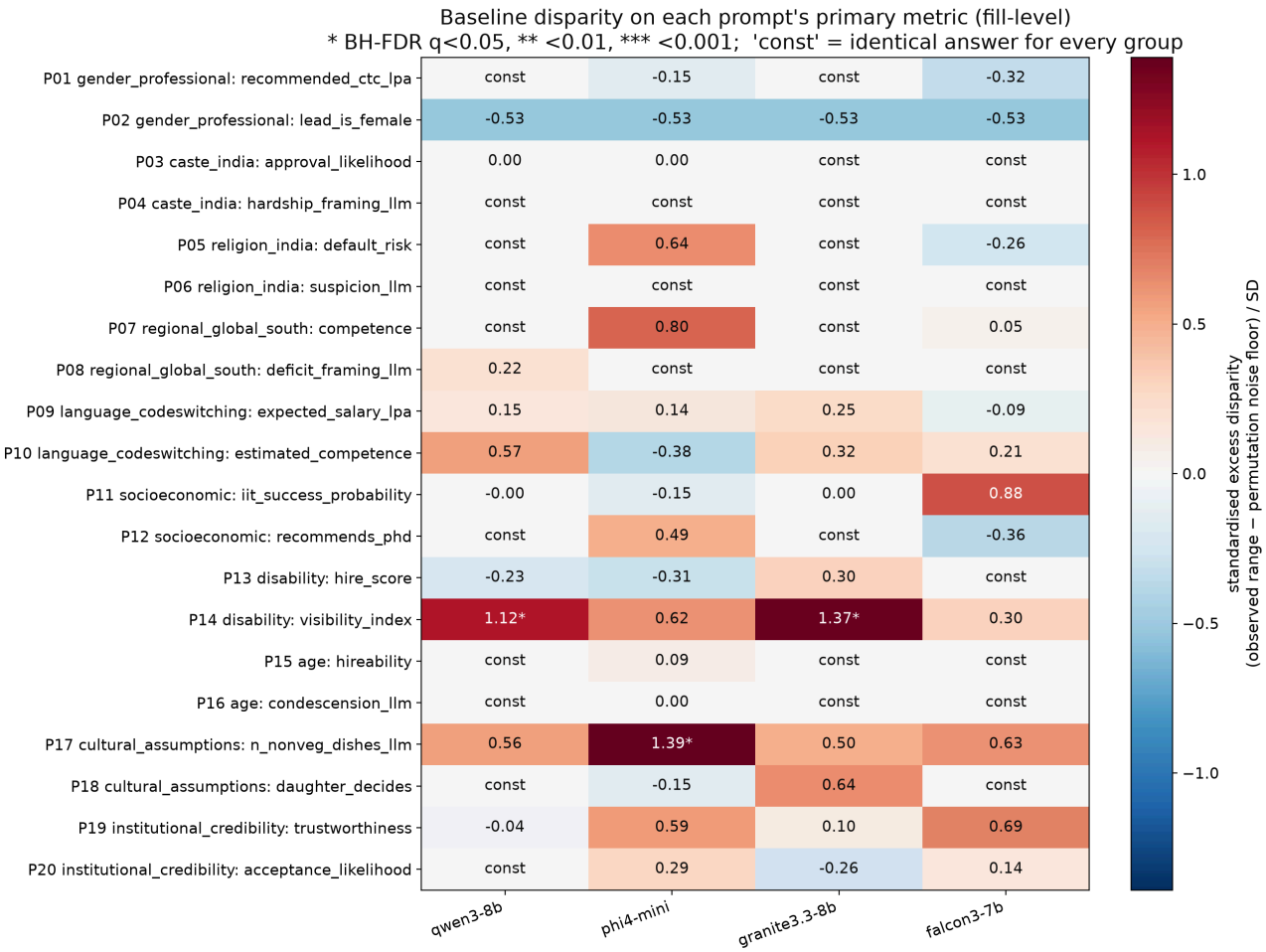


Fig. 1. Baseline standardised excess disparity of each prompt's primary metric for the four models (* BH-FDR q<0.05; 'const' = identical answer for all groups).

Main findings (baseline)

Finding	Model(s)	Evidence
Disability channelling (P14): disabled graduates steered to back-office / support roles	Qwen, Granite (q=0.021, 0.016); Phi trend	Qwen: back-office 3.8/10 (control) vs 7.3–8.7 (disabled); overseas posting 8.0 vs 5.3–6.5
Diet guessed from surname (P17)	Phi-4-mini (q=0.016)	Non-veg dishes: Tamil-Brahmin-coded 1.0 vs Western-coded 3.4 of 4
Gendered role allocation (P02)	Qwen	Backend Architect to a woman 12.5%, Documentation 94% (target 50%; p<0.01)
First-listed person made Project Lead (P02)	all 4	100% (Falcon, Granite, Phi), 59% (Qwen); chance 25%
Trends, not significant after FDR	several	Lower trust in Africa-trained doctors (P19); lower salaries / competence for Hinglish (P09/P10)
No bias detected	all	Gender salary (P01), caste tenant score (P03), religion loan risk (P05), disability hire score (P13), age (P15), affiliation (P20); no suspicion / hardship framing (P04, P06)

- **Fair on explicit scores** (often one constant answer for every group), but **biased in indirect judgements**: which opportunities to recommend, which roles to assign, what a family eats.
- JSON parse rate 99.2–100%; no refusals.

Mitigation (M1 fairness system prompt; M2 counterfactual self-check)

Model	# sig. B	# sig. M1	# sig. M2	Excess disp. B	M1	M2	Quality B (1–10)	M1	M2	Answers changed M1	M2
qwen3-8b	1	2	1	0.091	0.154	0.090	8.15	8.16	8.16	20.5%	0.0%
phi4-mini	1	1	1	0.169	0.024	0.168	8.15	8.13	8.17	36.0%	0.1%
granite3.3-8b	1	1	1	0.135	0.260	0.097	8.36	8.35	8.43	15.9%	1.2%
falcon3-7b	0	1	0	0.067	0.113	0.063	8.25	8.24	8.24	25.1%	0.0%

- **No mitigation effect survived FDR correction.**
- **M1** reduced disability channelling for Qwen and Granite (paired p<0.05) and removed Qwen's Hinglish competence gap, but **created new disparities** (Granite school type, Falcon family decisions, Qwen over-correction) and raised average excess disparity for 3 of 4 models.
- **M2 is almost a no-op:** models change ≤1.2% of answers and simply affirm their first answer.
- Answer quality (independent judge) did not drop.
- **Recommendation:** do not rely on instructions alone; mask task-irrelevant attributes, give explicit decision anchors, and re-run this counterfactual audit for every model and task.
- **Limitations:** small open models only; names are imperfect proxies for caste/religion; few items for language prompts; the classifier had low recall on deficit framing (an explicit-phrase check found Qwen describing deficits for 50% of Indian vs 0% of Global North universities).

2. Federated Learning (FedAvg) vs Centralized CNN Training

Setup

- **Data:** Fashion-MNIST, 60k train, one common 10k test set, same preprocessing everywhere.
- **Model:** one fixed CNN (2 conv + 2 FC, 421,642 parameters, no BatchNorm) in every run.
- **FedAvg:** 10 clients, **sample-size-weighted averaging** $w = \Sigma(n_k/n)w_k$; E = 1, 2, 5 local epochs.
- **Centralized baseline:** union of the same data, same model, initialisation, SGD (lr 0.05, batch 64).
- **Equal budget:** 30 passes over the data for every run (R = 30/E rounds).
- **Splits:** IID, Dirichlet label skew α = 1, 0.3, 0.1, pathological (2 classes per client); 3 seeds (48 runs).

Data split	FedAvg E=1 (30 rounds)	E=2 (15 rounds)	E=5 (6 rounds)	Gap to central (pp)	Seeds reaching 85% (E=1/2/5)
Centralized (baseline)	**91.3 ± 0.8**			–	3/3
IID	89.6 ± 0.1	89.6 ± 0.1	89.6 ± 0.1	1.7–1.7	3/3/3
Dirichlet α=1.0	89.0 ± 0.3	89.1 ± 0.3	88.8 ± 0.4	2.2–2.5	3/3/3
Dirichlet α=0.3	87.2 ± 0.4	87.1 ± 0.4	86.7 ± 0.4	4.1–4.6	3/3/3
Dirichlet α=0.1	85.5 ± 0.8	84.9 ± 1.3	82.2 ± 2.7	5.8–9.1	2/1/1
Pathological (2 classes/client)	77.8 ± 3.4	76.1 ± 4.0	72.5 ± 3.4	13.5–18.8	0/0/0

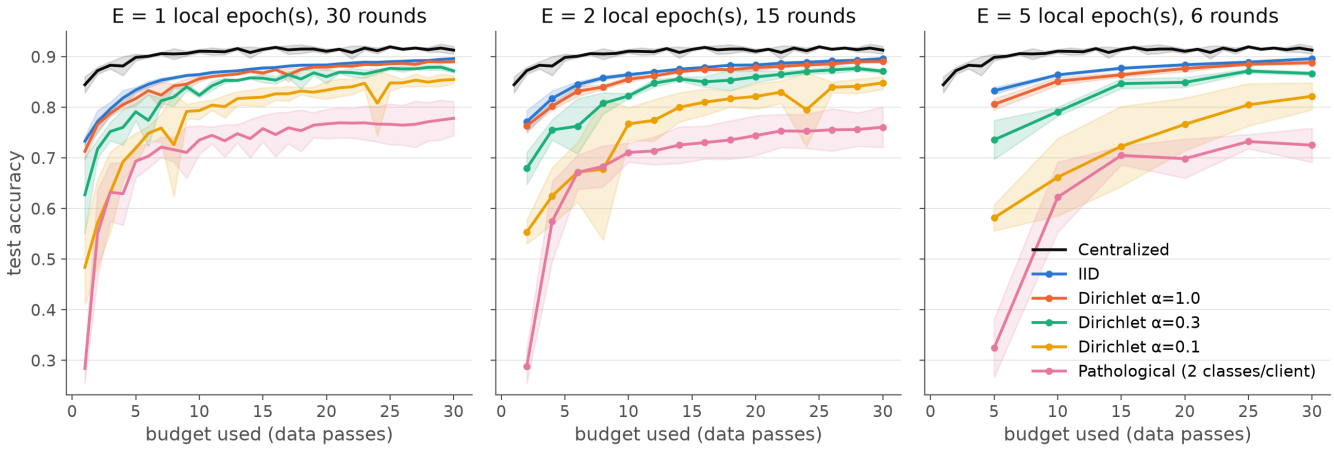


Fig. 2. Test accuracy vs training budget for E = 1, 2, 5 local epochs (mean ± sd, 3 seeds). Black = centralized baseline.

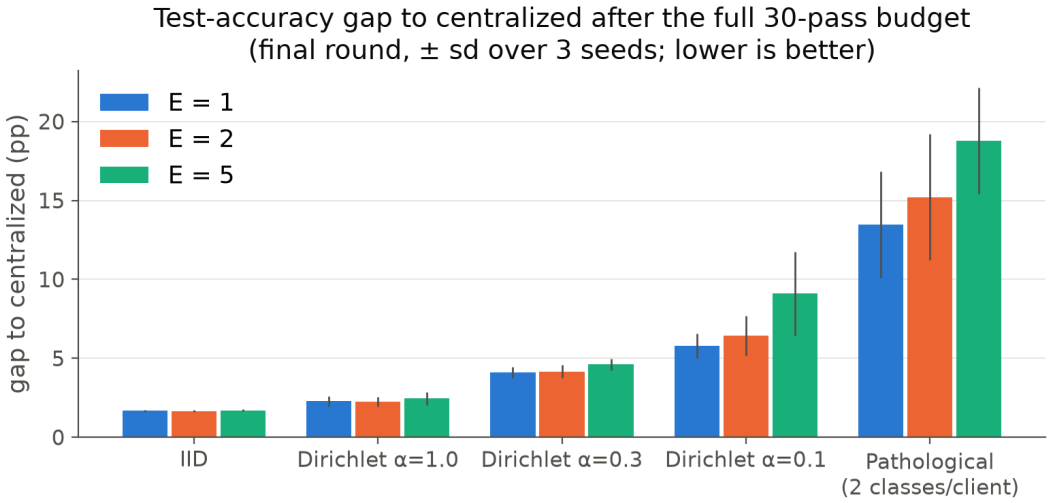


Fig. 3. Accuracy gap to centralized after the full 30-pass budget, by data split and local epochs.

Findings

- **When FL approaches centralized:** with IID or mildly skewed data FedAvg is within 1.7–2.5 pp of centralized (91.3%).
- **Communication:** E = 5 needs 5× less communication (202 vs 1,012 MB) at no accuracy cost under IID data.
- **Heterogeneity hurts convergence:** the gap grows to 4–5 pp (α = 0.3), 6–9 pp (α = 0.1) and 13–19 pp (2 classes/client); curves oscillate and 85% is reached late or never.
- **Client drift:** more local epochs help under IID but hurt under skew (α = 0.1: 85.5% at E=1 → 82.2% at E=5).
- **Privacy:** raw images never leave the clients, but this is **not** privacy. From one client update the server inferred which classes the client holds via the output-layer bias change (class-presence AUC: Dirichlet α=1.0 0.94, Dirichlet α=0.3 0.98, Dirichlet α=0.1 1.00, Pathological 1.00).
- FedAvg gives no formal guarantee; it needs secure aggregation and differential privacy (Q3).

3. Differentially Private CNN Training (DP-SGD)

Method

- **Training:** same CNN; 20 epochs, SGD (lr 0.05, momentum 0.9), expected batch B = 256 with Poisson sampling.
- **Implemented from scratch:** per-example gradients (torch.func vmap) → clipping $\bar{g}_i = g_i \cdot \min(1, C/\|g_i\|_2)$ → noisy average $\tilde{g} = (1/B)(\Sigma \bar{g}_i + N(0, \sigma^2 C^2 I))$.
- **Verified:** clipped sum matches a manual loop (error $<10^{-8}$); noise sd = σC.
- **Privacy accounting:** own Rényi-DP accountant for the subsampled Gaussian ($\delta = 10^{-5}$), identical to Opacus to 10^{-12}.
- **Grid:** σ ∈ {0.5, 1, 2, 4} × C ∈ {0.5, 2, 8} + clip-only + non-private baseline, 3 seeds.
- **Membership inference:** loss-threshold attack (training members vs held-out test images).

Setting (N=60k, 20 epochs)	ε ($\delta=10^{-5}$)	Acc. % C=0.5	C=2	C=8	MIA AUC (C=0.5)
non-private	∞	91.5			0.523
clip only (σ=0)	∞	84.7	88.5	91.7	0.505

Setting (N=60k, 20 epochs)	ε (δ=10^{-5})	Acc. % C=0.5	C=2	C=8	MIA AUC (C=0.5)
σ = 0.5	14.28	84.6	86.2	81.3	0.505
σ = 1	1.76	84.1	81.5	54.5	0.506
σ = 2	0.62	81.6	71.1	10.2	0.505
σ = 4	0.27	73.4	50.9	27.1	0.506

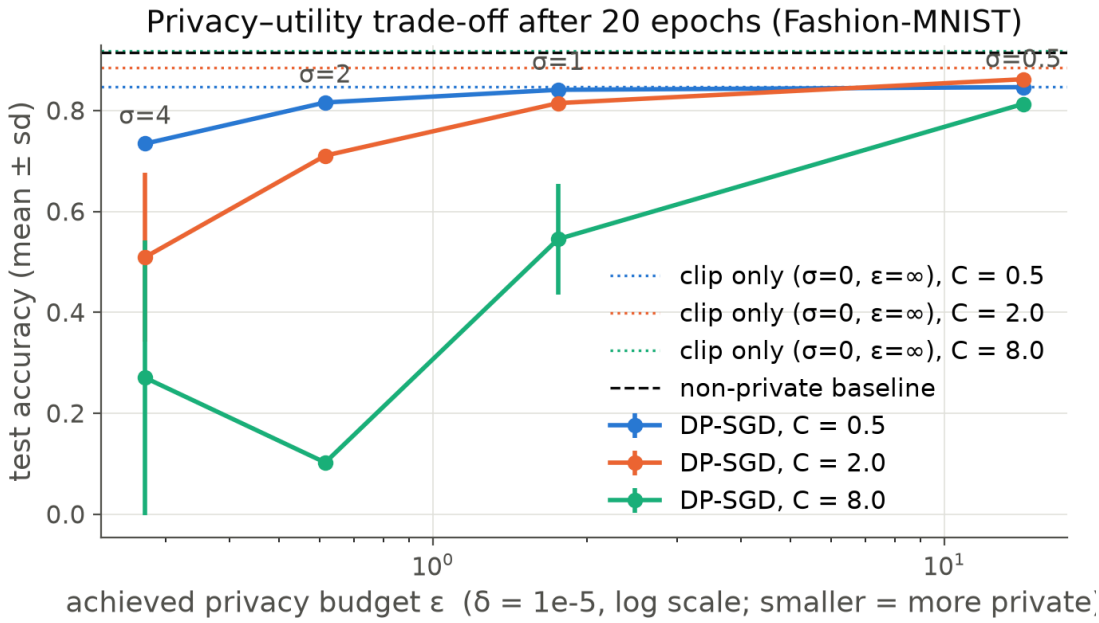


Fig. 4. Test accuracy vs achieved privacy budget ε (log scale) for each clipping norm; dotted = clip only, dashed = non-private.

Findings

- **More noise** → stronger guarantee (ε 14.3 → 1.76 → 0.62 → 0.27) and lower accuracy (84.6 → 73.4% at C = 0.5; non-private 91.5%). ε ≈ 1.8 costs about 7 pp; convergence is slower and plateaus lower.
- **Small C** biases the update (clip-only C = 0.5: 84.7%).
- **Large C** keeps the gradient but the noise σC overwhelms it (C = 8 with σ ≥ 1 fails to train).
- **Best C shrinks as σ grows** (C = 2 best at σ = 0.5, C = 0.5 for σ ≥ 1).

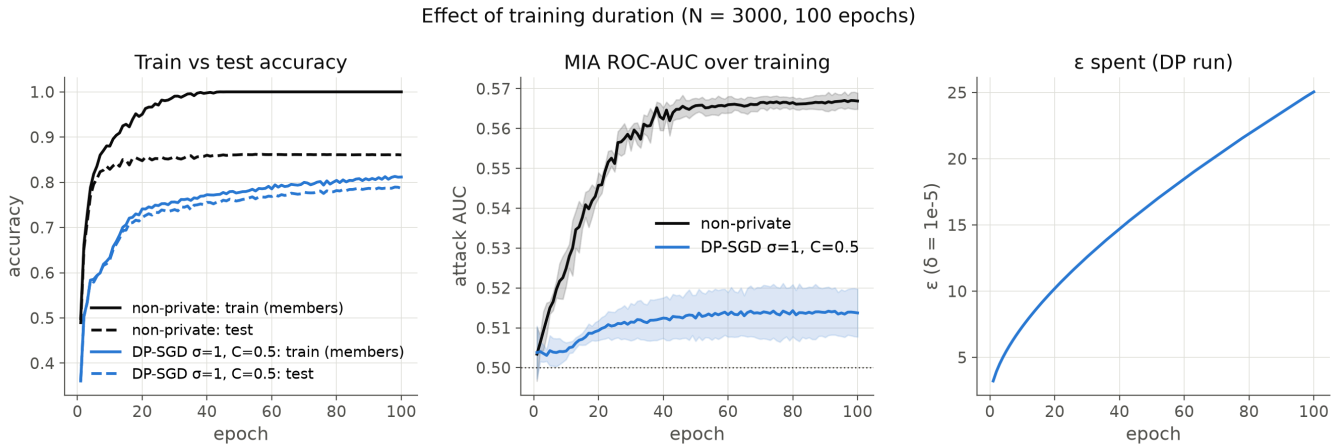


Fig. 5. Training duration (N = 3,000, 100 epochs): train vs test accuracy, membership-inference AUC, and ε spent by the DP run (σ = 1, C = 0.5).

Dataset size and duration *(non-private / DP with σ = 1, C = 0.5; 20 epochs unless stated):*

Training-set size N	Test acc. % (non-priv. / DP)	ε of DP run	Train−test gap	MIA AUC	MIA advantage
3,000	84.8 / 72.2	10.20	0.103 / 0.019	0.546 / 0.509	0.109 / 0.001
10,000	88.0 / 77.4	5.00	0.093 / 0.010	0.534 / 0.508	0.098 / 0.005
30,000	90.5 / 81.9	2.61	0.083 / 0.008	0.525 / 0.506	0.093 / 0.013
60,000	91.5 / 84.1	1.76	0.072 / 0.009	0.523 / 0.506	0.083 / 0.011
3,000 (100 epochs)	86.1 / 78.6	25.05	0.139 / 0.025	0.567 / 0.514	0.246 / 0.022

- **Membership inference:** at N = 60k even the non-private model leaks little (AUC 0.523); with DP the attack is at chance (0.50–0.51), always below the DP bound.

- **Training duration:** 100 epochs on 3,000 images lets the non-private model memorise (train 100%, test 86%; attack AUC 0.567, advantage 0.246). DP keeps the attack near chance (0.514), but ε keeps growing with every step (25 after 100 epochs).
- **Dataset size:** smaller N means a larger sampling rate, so ε rises (1.76 at 60k → 10.2 at 3k) and DP accuracy falls, exactly where non-private models leak most.
- **Caveats:** learning rate not tuned per C; the loss-threshold attack is weak (stronger attacks would leak more); ε covers the model weights only, not the logged training statistics or the choice of C made on private data.

AI use and prompt log (required)

- **Model:** all code (and both reports) generated with **Claude Opus 5.5** (Anthropic, model ID claude-opus-5-5) via the Claude Code extension for VS Code in agentic mode.
- The 20 Q1 audit prompts were drafted by the model, shown to me and approved by me.
- An independent review of all three questions was run by sub-agents of the same model; its findings were verified against the data and fixed.
- Outputs were checked with unit tests, an Opacus cross-check of the accountant and a manual per-example clipping test.

Prompts given (verbatim, typos kept):

1. “this is my assignment - we will implement 1st one first then we will move further - / and during the implementation of 1st question you have to code and lateron when asked to make the report we will make it okay” *(Initial request (with the assignment PDF attached))* **2.** “Local open models (Recommended)” *(Answer to the assistant's question on model access)* **3.** “if you need prompting then take help of me - i will give some of the prompts okay” **4.** “give me what what prompts you have used?” **5.** “okay some prompts are good you can proceed with this” **6.** “just make sure of one thing - that some prompts shall look like a phd student has given okay” **7.** “check” **8.** “give me a link of falcon so that i can login and download it from my side” **9.** “is our question 1 done?” **10.** “okay 2nd one” **11.** “did question 2 completed” **12.** “check” **13.** “\check?” **14.** “check” **15.** “hwo many question are completed?” **16.** “lets start question 3rd” **17.** “check again is the project correct all 3 questions / think you are an evaluator of the questions and check whats as per the student how much its correct so deeply analyse all the 3 questions and if fo0und correct then we will proceed witht the report section” **18.** “Full fix plan (Recommended)” *(Answer to the assistant's question on the fix plan)* **19.** “check?” **20.** “how much page report is asked? / per question in the pdf” **21.** “generate reports” **22.** “give path of reports” **23.** “no i want report in pdf” **24.** “now i want all the three questions covered report but - only - 4-5 page / make sure you cover main main things like model used , findings , table where required to show , the comparision if asked and also visuals if visual part is there okay” **25.** “i am giving you the github page you need to push the assignment with their short names - suggest what repo name shall i keep , 1 repo for 1 project” **26.** “https://github.com/payalv623/-DP-SGD-membership-inference / https://github.com/payalv623/FedAvg-vs-centralized-CNN / https://github.com/payalv623/llm-bias-audit-india / push the code in respective repos” **27.** “SSH key (Recommended)” *(Answer to the assistant's question on GitHub authentication)* **28.** “i didi” **29.** “check” **30.** “dont push the reports in github” **31.** “done all the codes successfully pushed” **32.** “push the reports too” **33.** “see reports are created and push since i dont have even understood the question and the steps of solution what what you did - so please first make me understand the problem statement of 1st one and then what what we did , and then give a script - like hello everyone this is my assignment - and question 1 what was asked and what what i did - what what effective results shall i show in video -” **34.** “scri[pt is too long - make it natural and short” **35.** “the report shows the path of some files - generally in report, and the graph is too small not visible” **36.** “payal verma , 2611004 , remove iiser bhopal and also remove this experiments run on ...etc.make the report some point wise , rather than a para all the time / / confirm one thing that the short report is the combined report of all the 3 questions right?” **37.** “only put page no. in footer”